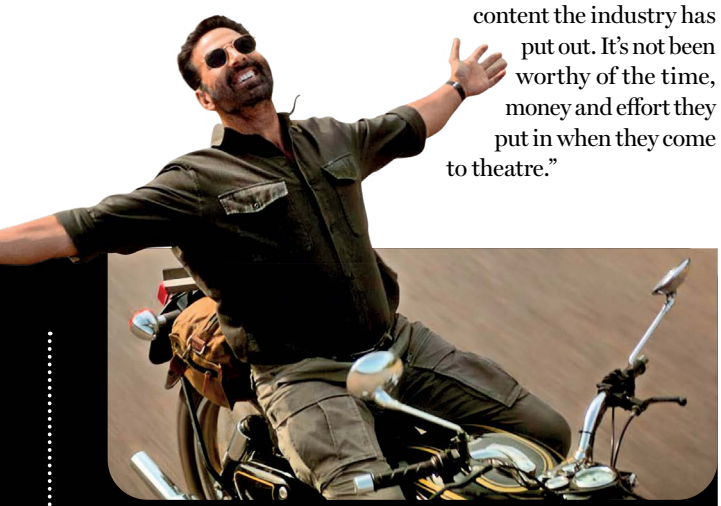
It's Raining THRILLERS

AFTER A DRY SUMMER SPELL, A FLOOD OF FRESH FILMS SHOULD BRING RELIEF TO PARCHED AUDIENCES

By SUHANI SINGH

Bollywood has been feeling the heat this summer. Halfway into 2024 and it's been a sluggish showing at the ticket windows so far, especially compared to the record-breaking last year, when not one but three films—*Pathaan*, *Gadar 2* and *Jawan*—set a new benchmark, crossing the Rs 500 crore mark nationally. So sorry was the Hindi cinema output in April-May that low footfalls compelled cinema operators to cancel shows choosing instead to screen cricket matches or re-releasing older films (*Rockstar*, *Lakshya*, *Swades*) instead. "What we are witnessing right now in the Hindi film industry is not just a lack of box office success, but the lack of confidence in our own content," says Akshaye Rathi, director, Aashirwad Theatres, citing the Lok Sabha election and IPL as factors contributing to the dry spell in revenues. "It's not the audience that has failed us, it is some really mediocre content the industry has put out. It's not been worthy of the time, money and effort they put in when they come to theatre."



SARFIRA
July 12

Director: Sudha Kongara
Starring: Akshay Kumar, Paresh Rawal
A Hindi remake of the five National Award-winning Tamil film *Soorarai Pottru*, which is inspired by the life of Captain G.R. Gopinath, who set up the low-cost airline Air Deccan against all odds

The highest earner of 2024 thus far, *Fighter*, collected Rs 200 crore in India, an underperformance given its budget (Rs 250 crore). Director Siddharth Anand's aerial action thriller had fuelled considerable hype for being India's very own star-studded (Deepika Padukone, Hrithik Roshan) *Top Gun*. The audience though thought little of it. Instead, the moneyspinners came from least expected quarters. *Shaitaan*, a home invasion horror centred around black magic starring Ajay Devgn and R. Madhavan, emerged as this year's surprise hit along with promising runs for women-fronted starrers such as *Article 370*, *Laapataa Ladies* and *Crew*. Honour for the biggest sleeper hit though belonged to *Munjya*, a horror comedy with no star in its cast and a CGI-created titular character, having minted Rs 85 crore so far. As the tentpoles fail to deliver, exhibitors like Rathi are hoping that more such "mid-segment films" emerge to beat the box office blues. "It's a matter of time before the one or two big-ticket films click to set the momentum not just in the content-producing fraternity but also the audience to turn up in cinemas," he added. "What's exciting is to wait for the films that come out of the blue and do well."

A WHOLE NEW WORLD

The monsoon slate is diverse but no film is likely to be bigger in 2024 than *Kalki 2898 AD* (June 27), the dystopian sci-fi action drama budgeted at an estimated Rs 600 crore and with a mammoth run time of three hours. The cast, too, is star-heavy, from thespian stalwarts Amitabh Bachchan and Kamal Haasan to popular actors in Prabhas and Deepika Padukone, who were sold on the ambitious vision of Nag Ashwin, the Telugu filmmaker best known for *Mahanati*. At a recent media event in Mumbai, Bachchan, who plays Ashwathama, praised the young writer-director for conceiving a project "that's so futuristic and so possible". "It's a great honour to be a part of it... to have worked in a set-up where they have actually gone beyond thinking what most of us have been doing all our lives in the film industry," he added.

With its landscape reminiscent of *Dune* and the Mad Max films, Ashwin sets his film in a time when Kaasi a.k.a. Varanasi